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DEVELOPMENT PLAN

HOLLOW GRAVES PROJECT

<https://apokriptos.github.io/aobscuragames/>



DEVELOPMENT CONTEXT & CONSTRAINTS

01

Hollow Graves is currently led and developed by Santiago Pérez Losanovscky as the active core developer, with an advanced playable prototype already containing most major gameplay systems.

02

Development is independently financed and therefore progresses at a part-time cadence. The existing build demonstrates the game's systems and direction; funding converts that foundation into sustained production.

03

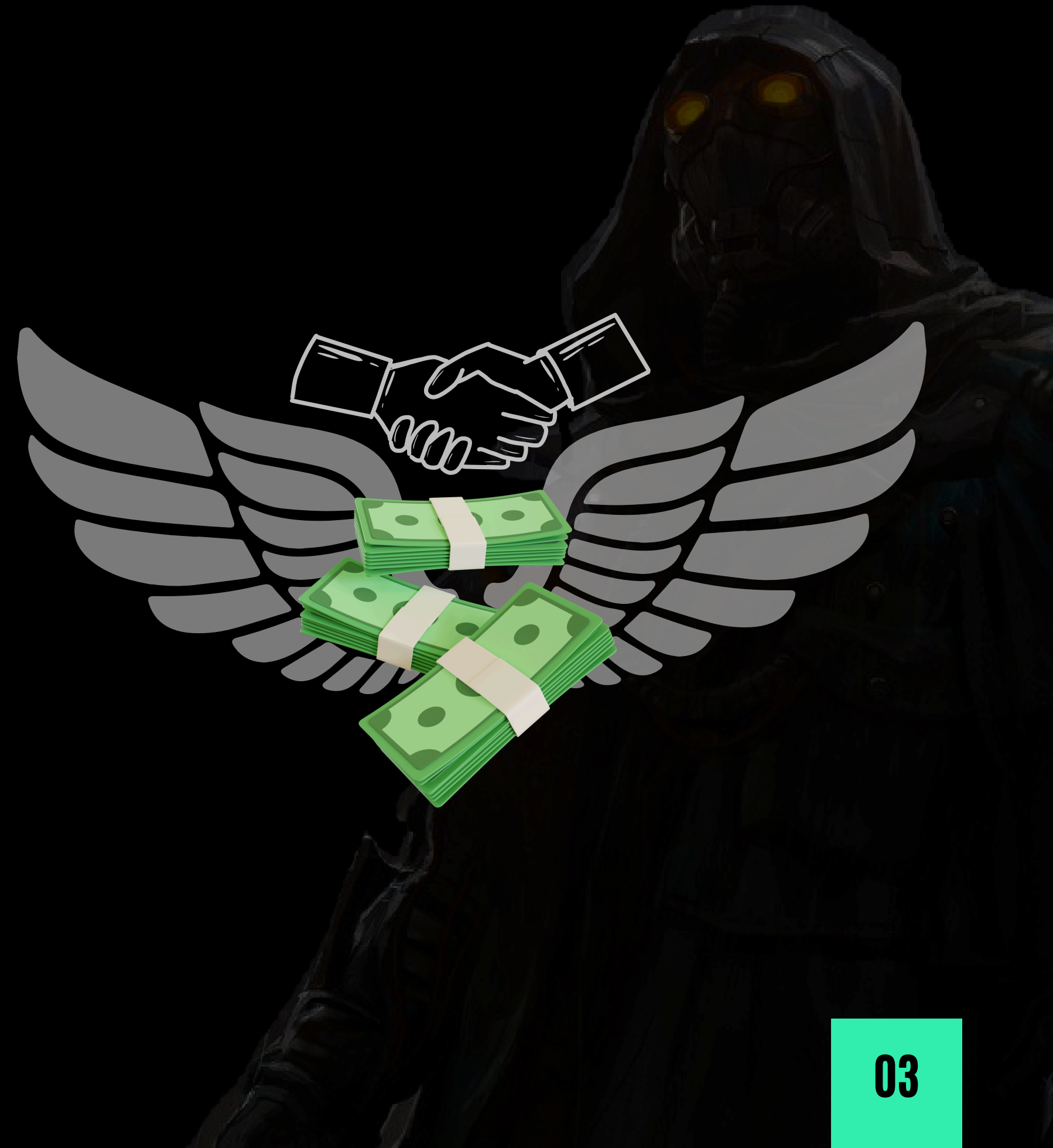
Scope is managed through clear milestones: advanced prototype refinement, a production-ready vertical slice, and full production. This keeps development realistic while allowing the team to scale without compromising the core design.

04

The project is structured to scale with secured budget. Aobscura Games has access to collaborators across the core disciplines required for production and can assemble a dedicated team when financing permits.

FUNDING STRATEGY

- Secure a publishing partnership and external financing for production.
- Target up to USD 500K, with the final budget and milestone structure defined with the partner according to scope. Lower financing would support a narrower vertical-slice phase rather than full production.
- Prioritize dedicated development time, original art and animation, specialist engineering, audio/VFX/QA support, technical optimization, and a polished Arrival demo.
- Keep co-development or investment as viable secondary paths, with grants and crowdfunding as fallback options.





MARKET POSITIONING & PLATFORM STRATEGY

CONSOLES

Hollow Graves is planned as a PC-first release, with console versions considered after the core production is established.

TARGET AUDIENCE

The game targets players who enjoy horror, exploration, narrative discovery, and systems-driven play, while broadening accessibility through meaningful agency and readable supernatural combat.

Its Argentine identity is treated as a creative advantage: a distinct cultural lens applied to a genre and setting that are usually dominated by familiar references.

PRODUCT POSITION



The game sits between action-horror and investigative horror: it preserves vulnerability and dread while giving players limited tools to understand, reveal, and confront supernatural threats.

Its systemic astral ecology, Argentine sci-fi identity, environmental storytelling, and light-based combat create clear hooks for players in love with the genre yet hungry for an innovative experience.



PRODUCTION PARTNERSHIP

A publishing partner would enable the transition from advanced prototype to dedicated production through:

- Finalized scope, budget, and milestone planning
- Dedicated full-time development cadence
- Team expansion across art, animation, audio, engineering, VFX, and QA
- Technical refactoring, optimization, and production support

NEXT PHASE

- Validate the project at EVA B2B
- Deliver a stronger Arrival vertical slice
- Establish a production budget and team plan
- Convert publisher conversations into a concrete financing path

HOLLOW GRAVES

2027 ROADMAP

Advanced Prototype → Production-Ready Demo

SOME
PLACES
SHOULD
STAY
BURIED

Q1 2027

01

SYSTEMS CONSOLIDATION

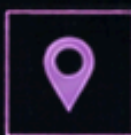


- Refine the core investigation → power restoration → escalation loop
- Iterate the Astral Ecosystem as a systemic horror pillar
- Redesign the Radar for richer supernatural detection
- Improve feedback, clarity, and gameplay readability

Q2 2027

Q2

ARRIVAL LEVEL PR



- Build and polish the "Arrival" introduction level
- Quarantine sequence, restored power flow, and station hub access
- Transmission objective and tram-station progression
- Environmental storytelling and Reaper-cult traces

Q3 2027

03

TECH & CONTENT UPGRADE



- Refactor performance-sensitive systems into C++
- Optimize performance and harden enemy architecture
- Integrate boss ghost plus 2–3 basic ghost types
- Expand animation, combat feedback, and encounter quality

Q4 2027

04

VERTICAL SLICE POLISH



- Art, audio, VFX, and presentation polish
- Playtesting, balancing, and usability refinement
- Finalize a production-ready demo
- Prepare the project for publishing and production talks



WITH FUNDING



Accelerates team expansion and content production



Supports original art, animation, engineering, audio, VFX, and QA



Enables transition from solo development to dedicated production



GAME DESIGN



GAME DESIGN



GAME DESIGN

GAME DESIGN — NEXT MILESTONE OBJECTIVES

A

Finalize the investigation → power restoration → escalation loop and the design pillars that define the Arrival demo.

B

Formalize the Astral Ecosystem as a systemic horror engine: fully define how it grows, reacts, coordinates, and pressures the player over time.

C

Refine the Radar, Clues, Lantern combat, Prayers, weak points, and feedback so the existing systems read as one coherent experience.

D

Maintain an accessible, scalable Game Design Document that supports the demo, production planning, and future team onboarding.

Focus

Hollow Graves is driven by investigation, player agency, and systemic horror. Authored objectives define what must be accomplished, while the Astral Ecosystem determines how supernatural opposition grows, reacts, and pressures the player as those objectives are pursued.

2027 Priorities

The next design phase consolidates the advanced prototype into a production-ready demo: refining the investigation–power–escalation loop, the Astral Ecosystem, radar behavior, combat readability, player feedback, and the relationship between authored goals and systemic pressure.

GAME DESIGN

Player Agency

The world and required objectives are strongly authored, but players retain meaningful freedom in route choice, investigation depth, use of clues, avoidance or confrontation, and how aggressively they engage with the supernatural systems.

Difficulty & Accessibility

Difficulty is systemic and reactive rather than built around a fixed sequence of scripted encounters. The ecosystem grows stronger and more coordinated over time, while rest, anticipation, route choice, and player decisions create natural variation in intensity.



LEVEL DESIGN — NEXT MILESTONE OBJECTIVES

LEVEL DESIGN



LEVEL DESIGN



LEVEL DESIGN

A

Design and iterate Arrival from quarantine through power restoration, hub access, transmission objectives, and the final tram unlock.

B

Define the level's affordance rules and communicate them organically through signage, lighting, machinery, maps, and spatial composition.

C

Integrate the Astral Ecosystem into traversal and encounters so systemic threats interact meaningfully with authored objectives and multiple routes.

D

Maintain a scalable Level Design Document covering layout rules, pacing, naming, encounter logic, and production standards for future areas.

E

Deliver a polished Arrival demo that proves the complete level loop, supports playtesting, and serves as the reference for full production.

Structure

The campaign is organized as functional station areas connected through hubs and transit. Arrival acts as the introduction: the player reaches Belerofonte III during a shutdown, passes through quarantine, restores power, gains access to the main hub, follows traces of the Reaper cult, reaches the transmission station, and ultimately unlocks the tram into the wider station.

2027 Scope

The next level-design milestone is a polished Arrival demo that represents the intended production quality and validates the complete introductory flow, from quarantine and power restoration to hub access, communications, and the tram station.

LEVEL DESIGN

Gameplay Loop

Arrival follows the core loop: investigate while power is offline → restore systems → survive an increasingly active supernatural ecosystem → complete the required objective chain → reach the tram and enter the wider station.

Guidance & Horror Pacing

Navigation relies on strong diegetic affordances—lighting, signage, maps, machinery, and environmental cues. Authored horror beats establish rhythm, while the Astral Ecosystem supplies systemic pressure so repeated play is not reduced to memorizing scripted encounters.



PROGRAMMING—NEXT MILESTONE OBJECTIVES

DEV

A

Profile and refactor performance-sensitive systems into C++ while preserving fast designer-facing iteration in Blueprints.



B

Implement and iterate the Astral Ecosystem as a modular enemy network capable of growing, coordinating, adapting, and pressuring the player.

DEV

C

Redesign the Radar so supernatural detection communicates more than simple proximity and sound while remaining legible under pressure.



D

Improve feedback, debugging, playtest visibility, modularity, and internal tooling so systems remain easy to understand and expand.

DEV

E

Harden enemy AI architecture so individual ghosts and ecosystem roles can share foundations while supporting distinct hunting and combat behavior.

Focus

Programming supports every layer of Hollow Graves, from investigation and combat to enemy behavior, level systems, and internal tools. The project is built in Unreal Engine 5.8, with Blueprints used extensively for rapid front-end implementation and iteration.

DEV

2027 Scope

Harden the advanced prototype through:

- C++ refactors for performance-sensitive systems
 - Astral Ecosystem iteration
 - Radar redesign
- Performance profiling and optimization
- Stronger enemy architecture
- Production tooling

Technical Philosophy

The technical strategy is modular and designer-facing: keep iteration-heavy gameplay readable in Blueprints, move performance-critical or reusable foundations into C++, and maintain clear interfaces between both layers so the project can scale with additional developers.

Constraints & Sustainability

The current codebase is maintained by the project lead. If financing allows, production would add an experienced C++ engineer for optimization and lower-level systems while design-facing implementation remains fast and accessible through Blueprints.



ANIMATION



ANIMATION



ANIMATION

ANIMATION—NEXT MILESTONE OBJECTIVES

A

Develop and polish the principal ghost rig with a reusable foundation for future supernatural enemies.

B

Create the boss ghost's key animation set: movement, attacks, reactions, abilities, interactions, and state changes.

C

Build readable animation sets for approximately two to three basic ghost types, sharing rigs or logic where useful without erasing their identity.

D

Integrate animation states with AI, combat, collisions, weak points, and feedback so behavior changes remain legible during play.

E

Treat ritual-site, cleansing, and other secondary-objective animation needs as stretch scope after the core Arrival demo is stable.

Role in the Experience

Animation in **Hollow Graves** is primarily responsible for **enemy readability and combat feedback**. Since the game is first-person, enemy movement, reactions, and transformations are key to communicating threat, state changes, and player impact, while also reinforcing the horror tone.

2027 Scope

Focused demo enemy set:

- 1 principal boss ghost
- 2–3 basic ghost types
- Quality, readability, and strong state feedback over roster size

ANIMA-TION

Style & Direction

The animation style is **expressive, unsettling, and intentionally unnatural**, designed to evoke discomfort and reinforce the paranormal themes. Animations prioritize creepiness and clarity over realism, using exaggerated motion and timing to support both fear and gameplay understanding.

Production Approach

Animation production favors reusable rigs, modular state logic, and iterative passes that can scale into future enemies. Baseline demo scope comes first; additional ritual or cleansing-specific content is treated as later expansion once the core encounter set is stable.



NARRATIVE—NEXT MILESTONE OBJECTIVES

NARRATIVE



NARRATIVE



NARRATIVE

A

Design the core narrative arc of Arrival, from quarantine and power restoration to first access to the station proper.

B

Establish the Reaper cult through environmental traces, incidents, symbols, and consequences without exposing the campaign's major revelations.

C

Write and implement the transmission objective, contact attempt, and mysterious information source as hooks into the wider campaign.

D

Integrate narrative clues with navigation, objectives, ghost encounters, and systemic escalation so story discovery remains part of play.

E

Plant optional mysteries and deeper evidence that reward investigation without revealing the central twists of Hollow Graves.

Worldbuilding & Lore

Narrative exists to fuel curiosity and exploration. The station's history, its downfall, and the tragedy of its inhabitants are uncovered through investigation. Lore is not decorative: understanding ghosts, rituals, and past events directly informs how players survive and progress.

2027 Scope

By the demo's end, the player has arrived at a silent station, survived quarantine, restored critical systems, entered the hub, discovered traces of the Reaper cult, attempted to establish contact through the transmission station, encountered a mysterious source of information, and reached the tram into the wider station.

NARRA- TIVE

Narrative Delivery

Storytelling is primarily environmental and experiential. Quarantine systems, abandoned spaces, cult traces, communications, ghost behavior, clues, logs, and optional voice content reveal what happened without relying on exposition or spoiling major twists.

Narrative Philosophy

The demo is designed to create questions rather than answer the campaign's major mysteries. Core plot hooks are explicit enough to establish stakes and curiosity, while deeper revelations remain layered behind environmental evidence, optional investigation, and future areas.



ART — NEXT MILESTONE OBJECTIVES

ART



ART



ART

A

Define the finalized visual language of Belerofonte III with a specific production focus on the Arrival and quarantine areas.

B

Establish the Reaper cult's symbols, materials, color language, props, and environmental traces for the introduction level.

C

Finalize the principal ghost and two to three basic ghost concepts so they can move into production-ready 3D and animation.

D

Create Arrival environment mockups with signage, quarantine systems, visual clues, cult traces, and spatial storytelling.

E

Refine Cástor's visual identity through signature tools and first-person presentation, and polish the investigation/combat interface.

Visual Language

Clarity through contrast:

- Human technology — sterile, rounded, clean
- Astral entities — purple, magenta, and light blue
- Reaper cult — black, red, and rigid angular forms

Player & Interface Design

Cástor's identity is communicated through first-person presentation, signature tools, and diegetic interfaces. Investigation and combat UI are designed to remain immersive while clearly communicating the information needed under pressure.

ART

Environmental Identity

Arrival establishes the station's visual baseline through quarantine infrastructure, dormant systems, sterile technology, and the contrast created when power returns and supernatural corruption becomes more visible. Reaper cult traces disrupt that order with a harsher visual language.

Enemy & Entity Design

Ghost and Astral designs communicate both narrative identity and systemic role. Silhouette, corruption, movement, and visual effects help players read what an entity is doing without reducing the supernatural to conventional enemy classes.

THANK YOU.



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